



TAMARA KARSAVINA, c. 1910

The sensational Russian prima ballerina is shown here, in a painting by Jacques-Emile Blanche, wearing the costume of the Firebird in Stravinsky's ballet of the same name.

Meteoric rise

Around 1908, the talk in cultural circles in Paris was of the exciting performances of Russian opera being staged there by the impresario Sergei Diaghilev, who now planned to start up a ballet company as well. Diaghilev, based in St. Petersburg, was in search of a composer for a new work, *The Firebird*. He had been impressed by Stravinsky's brilliantly written short orchestral